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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/62063422.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Major Character Death

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by Monika-s Moniker (Dan_Francisco)

Summary

The Horde is coming. Adora has half an hour to get her ruined regiment out of the line of fire.

"Okay, we have to be packed up in thirty minutes!" Adora shouted. "I need everything on these trucks by then!"

A smattering of activity flooded Adora's headquarters as aides and HQ troops scrambled to gather documents, break down communications equipment, and burn or destroy anything they couldn't fit on the back of a truck. The Horde was descending upon them with their newest and most lethal tanks and armored personnel carriers and if what the remnants of Adora's regiment were telling her – the Horse was *close.* Too close for her comfort. She'd already set up picket forces well ahead of the headquarters to give advance warning if – and when – the Horde started their attack, but given they'd been hounded by constant attacks for the last four hours… it was going to come. All just a matter of *when.*

"Who's in command at Phase Line Forest?" Catra asked as she snatched one of the few remaining maps out of a soldier's hands. She was still clad in her tanker's uniform, hair trimmed down to fit underneath the leather helmet as she stared at the marks and lines.

"Bow is," Adora said. "He's got some anti-tank weapons and about a half platoon with him."

Catra sighed and shook her head. "Fuck. Jin-Ho! Where the *fuck* are you?!"

"About to mount up!" Jin-Ho answered. Nearby his squad of light tanks roared onto the scene as the lead one, numbered 022, shuddered to a stop. "What's up?"

"Get to Phase Line Sea," Catra ordered. "You're backstopping Bow and his infantry. Don't be a fucking hero."

Jin-Ho flashed his signature smirk and sent off a two-fingered salute at Catra. "You know me, Catra. She's no *Grim Dawn,* but we'll make it work."

"Yeah, yeah," Catra replied, waving Jin-Ho off as he hoisted himself into his tank. "Adora, where do you need my tanks?"

Catra had herself a platoon's worth of medium tanks, good in a fight and could knock out a Horde tank or two – last time Adora checked, anyway. The Horde wasn't going to give up without a fight but she was loathe to use Catra in the picket line. "I need your tanks close by," Adora finally said. "Keep an eye out. Just in case." Catra nodded. They both know what was unsaid. *Make sure we get out.*

Distant artillery thundered across the plains and forests. Not much time left now. Adora ran back into the headquarters tent, radio crackling with reports from Bow's scouts and the frontline picket troop while Catra made herself scarce. *So much junk!* How much had they *left* here before the Horde came? Entirely too much, apparently. Soldiers flashed past her out of her peripheral vision as they carried supplies, equipment, documents, and anything else that could be loaded onto the back of their trucks. Everything seemed so important when they made camp here. Old recon reports, manuals for maintenance, photographs that once had a purpose but long lost to the chaos of war and a hasty retreat. "You! Take these, go burn them!" Adora shoved a handful of yesterday's recon reports into a passing soldier's hands, not even looking up to see who it was.

*"This is Bow! They're here, I repeat, the Horde is here!"* Adora's blood ran cold as she swallowed hard. They'd come a *lot* faster than she thought they would. Outside the command tent the panicked breakdown of the headquarters turned into a chaotic scramble, a cacophony of noise reflected by the increasing urgency and desperation in each soul's voice. She could hear the artillery even from this far out. Undoubtedly the Horde had brought up their big guns, and she didn't blame them – if it were her, *she'd* want to have everything on-hand to knock out the Princesses.

*Okay, focus. What's important? What's not?* Adora ran a hand through her hair as soldiers swept up documents and tore down equipment. File cabinets went out. Boxes full of food carted away. Fuel? Nobody knew where it was. One sergeant stopped trying to take down tacks and pins one-by-one and just started wheeling out an entire corkboard full of intelligence. She began to understand there was alarmingly little she could do now to affect the speed and the only tool she had was the people under her. Bow. Catra. Glimmer. Mermista. Perfuma. Entrapta, Scorpia, Jin-Ho… there was only one thing she *could* do. Buy time. Not her, but… she had to order them out. Bow and Jin-Ho were already ahead, already in contact in Bow's case… and she needed them, needed *everyone* to buy as much time as possible.

Even if that time was paid for in blood.

Maybe if it was four hours ago, maybe if it had been before her force had been decimated by a strenuous and unrelenting Horde assault, she wouldn't be in this position. She wouldn't even have to contemplate this scenario. But because of choices *she* had made, orders *she* had given, *she* was here now. Adora had no other option. She took a deep breath to calm herself (it didn't work) and picked up the radio. "Bow, report, what's the situation?"

*"They're everywhere!"* Adora didn't need to know those were gunshots and artillery on the other end of the line. *"I count a dozen, no, two dozen Horde tanks and hundreds of infantry! We're going to be overwhelmed here!"*

Shouting garbled by the radio, but Adora could pick out bits and pieces. *Need ammo. She's hit. Flank. In front. Left. Right.*

*Destroyed.* "Bow, do what you can. Jin-Ho's tank squad is right behind you."

*"We're not gonna last more than two minutes! We need him up here* ***now!"***

*"Adora, if we speed up we can make-"*

"No, absolutely not. Stay at Phase Line Sea, Jin-Ho. Bow, if you can, make a fighting withdraw but delay as long as possible. We need another twenty minutes to get ourselves sorted here."

" *We-get that recoilless back up now! That tank's-"*

*Silence.*

Adora knew what it meant. Jin-Ho knew what it meant. Anybody listening on that channel knew what it meant. Phase Line Forest had collapsed. Only Jin-Ho's tanks at Phase Line Sea and Glimmer's infantry fighting vehicles at Phase Line Cloud remained between the Horde and the headquarters. "Jin-Ho, come in."

*"Reporting. We're holding at Phase Line Sea."*

"Twenty minutes. We need to last that long."

*"Understood. We'll do our best."*

Adora nodded. It was the only thing she could do as her heart fell into her stomach. She couldn't get the idea of Bow desperately holding out, doing everything in his power to stave off the Horde, everything to stay *alive,* away from her mind. It didn't work. Every blink of her eyes brought the visage of Bow staring down a hostile

tank front and center. *Okay, focus.* Try to push forward. Try to get centered. "Glimmer, come in."

*"Here."* Adora didn't have to see her face to know that she was already grieving. Already bawled her eyes out. Voice marked with terseness.

"Are your vehicles ready at Phase Line Cloud?"

*"We can push up, support Jin-Ho's squad-"*

"No, negative, do *not.* He'll have to come to you. Jin-Ho, you reading me?"

A heavy sigh radiated out from the headset. *"Yeah, crystal. We're- oh shit, gunner, sabot, tank!"*

*Fuck.* The Horde was already at Phase Line Sea. It couldn't have been more than three or five minutes between Forest falling and them making contact at Sea. If this kept up… even now, even above the din of a headquarters breaking down and bugging out, Adora could hear the distant sound of tank fire.

*"Full platoon of tanks! Gunner, right right right! Fire! We've taken two down, need immediate artillery fire, coordinates to follow!"*

"Understood," Adora replied, rapidly scribbling down the coordinates Jin-Ho rattled out on the few scraps of paper left. She'd have to get rid of this after. Couldn't give anything to the Horde.

*"Adora, we can-"*

"I don't want to hear it, Glimmer. Hold in place. Fourteen minutes, that's all we need."

More panicked shouting, more hustle, more crashing. Ever-present sound of people handing off crates and throwing them into the back of trucks. Engines starting up, people banging on steel cargo beds, rifles being locked and loaded. Every second felt like an eternity. Fourteen minutes? May as well have been fourteen years. Artillery was getting closer and closer, friendly fire missions mixing with the enemy's as they undoubtedly were raining down hell on Jin-Ho and his tanks.

*"Adora! We're taking heavy casualties!"* Jin-Ho's voice. Not calm anymore. Gone was his usual carefree cadence, the lightness that was usually in his words. Only thing left was panic and stress. *"I'm two tanks down, we're falling back to Phase Line Cloud!"*

Okay. Okay, not great, not terrible. It wasn't *ideal* by any circumstance, but she could… she could figure something out. "I'll send another fire mission to your coordinates. Use it to cover your retreat."

*"Understood, we'll-"* Silence. She heard a faint "loaded" in the background. Must have been engaging another tank. That cutoff… that cutoff was Jin-Ho's tank getting destroyed. Adora felt her throat tighten, mouth dryer than any desert she knew of. How much time?

"Glimmer…" Adora said. She felt *exhausted.* Physically, emotionally, mentally. This wasn't how this was supposed to go. "Glimmer, nine minutes. It's all we need."

*"I know."* Even over the radio, Adora knew. Adora knew this was the last time she'd be speaking to Glimmer again. There were just too many tanks, too much infantry, not enough time or people to hold it all off. Glimmer's IFVs weren't too far away from the headquarters. She could hear them moving into position, hear the preparation barrage from the Horde. They knew. They already knew. They were already *here.* Adora left the command tent, since it had been picked clean of anything that wasn't nailed down

or destroyed, and looked west towards Phase Line Cloud. There, about seven hundred meters away from the HQ, was Glimmer and her little platoon of infantry fighting vehicles. There was Glimmer, basically all alone, against the advanced dust cloud of the Horde. Adora didn't need binoculars to know what was coming.

Even from here she could see first contact. A Horde tank got the first shot off on one of Glimmer's IFVs. Not hers. Not yet, anyway. The dismounts barely even got a chance to get out before the entire vehicle exploded, sending the turret sky-high and chunks of the hull across the plain in front of her. She stared at the incoming wave of steel ahead of her as it overwhelmed Glimmer's squad in short order. A glance at her watch told her all they needed was six more minutes.

"Catra…" Adora said, a heavy sigh accompanying her barely-concealed reluctance.

"You need my platoon to go out," Catra replied. She solemnly nodded and tugged on her field jacket. "I get it."

A deep lump formed in her throat. Adora tried to force it down, but her body refused to obey her commands. "I wouldn't ask if I had any other option." She glanced over at the trucks. Just a little longer, but that little bit might just be the difference between being caught and escaping. "They're almost here."

"Don't worry Adora. We'll get the job done." Catra stepped off to mount up in her tank. Slowly, agonizingly, they lurched forward into the hell of artillery fire and incoming tanks just ahead of them. Adora could do frustratingly little except watch and hope. The artillery fire was right on top of them now and forced her to back off. She could see Catra's tanks, see *her* fighting unbuttoned, desperately waving flags to signal to the friendly tanks what to do, where to go, who to shoot.

“Ma’am, we’re ready, we have to go *now.”*

Adora took in a deep, unsteady breath. She had to. She couldn’t stay and fight, even if she wanted to. If she was killed here… it’d be a coup for the Horde, and the worst defeat imaginable for her and the Resistance. Begrudgingly Adora walked away and climbed into a truck. The sight and sounds of a raging delaying action slowly faded until the only thing she could see on the horizon was the sight of a tank’s turret – alarmingly similar to Catra’s – violently flying into the air.

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